# Sungyoun Chung

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## Education

Ph.D., Economics, University of Colorado Boulder — *expected May 2027*
*Advisor: Tania Barham*

M.A., Economics, University of Colorado Boulder — 2024

M.A., Economics, Dongguk University, Seoul, South Korea — 2022

B.A., Economics, Dongguk University, Seoul, South Korea — 2020

## Research Interests

Primary: Health Economics, Public Economics, Household Finance, Economics of Aging
Secondary: Labor Economics, Applied Microeconomics

## Job Market Paper

### When the CFO Dies: The Wealth Cost of Succession in Older Households

Within couples, one spouse typically manages the household's wealth. This paper calls that spouse the household's CFO and asks what losing the CFO costs the household that survives. Using the Health and Retirement Study, which records which spouse manages the money, I compare couples that lose the CFO with couples that lose the non-CFO spouse to the same event, in a difference-in-differences with couple fixed effects on a balanced panel of 1,124 couples followed from six years before the death to four years after, and in a stacked triple difference across event timing. Losing the CFO reduces the surviving household's net worth by about 16 percent, roughly $98,000 at the mean, relative to losing the non-CFO spouse. The loss appears at the first interview after the death and does not recover over the following four years. It sits in the parts of the estate that pass through the succession, the retirement account, bank balances, and home equity, and not in the investments that demand attention. What governs the loss is the CFO's cognition, not the survivor's. Losing a CFO who was still managing the money costs 23 percent of net worth, losing one whose cognition had already declined costs nothing, and life insurance halves the loss. The evidence identifies a succession cost, incurred when the CFO dies and not recovered, the price of settling an estate that the person who understood it no longer runs.

## Working Papers

### When Simpler Taxes Meet Aging Minds: Cognitive Decline and Portfolio Reallocation after a State Income Tax Reform

*Third Year Paper Award, Department of Economics, University of Colorado Boulder (2024–2025)*

Older Americans hold most of the nation's equity wealth, yet many face cognitive decline that may impair their response to changing financial incentives. I study North Carolina's 2014 income tax reform, which replaced a three-bracket progressive schedule with a flat 5.8% rate, lowering and simplifying the tax on investment income. Using a balanced panel from the Health and Retirement Study and a difference-in-differences design with inverse probability weights, I find that the reform raised stock market participation by 3.0 percentage points and equity holdings by roughly 35%, while safe asset and IRA balances fell by about a quarter. A triple-difference design shows that the response is concentrated among cognitively intact respondents. Those whose word recall declined by 20% or

more before the reform did not reallocate on any margin. Because the reform simplified rather than complicated the tax schedule, the results indicate that the capacity to recognize and act on a changed environment, not tax complexity, constrains older households' portfolio adjustment.

## Publications

**Does Lawyers' Ability Enhance Litigation Success? Evidence from Korean Tax Appeal Cases**

*with Inyeob Ji*

*Korean Journal of Law and Economics*, 18(3): 209–230, 2021 (in Korean)

The present article investigates determinants of litigation outcomes. To this end, it examines Korean Supreme Court decisions from which logit regression models are formed and estimated. Its findings suggest that legal representation by large law firms and litigation attorneys (as opposed to advisory attorneys) contribute to litigation success for plaintiff taxpayers. Also, it appears that plaintiff taxpayers have a higher probability of a favorable judgment in national tax cases as opposed to regional tax cases.

## Works in Progress

The Long Reach of the ACA Dependent Mandate: Older Parents' Insurance, Labor Supply, and Wealth

## Research Experience

Graduate Research Assistant, University of Colorado Boulder — Summer 2025, Summer 2026

*Department of Economics, Reporting to Prof. Tania Barham*

*Randomized evaluation of the ReHire Colorado transitional jobs program for the Colorado Department of Human Services, using linked state administrative data (LINC)*

Research Assistant, Dongguk University, Seoul — 2020–2021

- "A Study of Potential Financial Risk Factors through Case Analysis," with Prof. Taejun Lim, Korean Econometric Society (2021)
- "The Economic Effects of Delaware Corporate Law," with Prof. Inyeob Ji, Federation of Korean Industries (2021)
- "Comparative Analysis of Terms and Conditions of Major Overseas Telecommunication Companies," with Prof. Jooyong Jun, Korea Information Society Development Institute (2020)
- "Database Construction and Management for the Minimum Wage Policy," with Prof. Woo-Hyung Hong, Korean Association of Public Finance (2020)
- "Analysis of the Impact of Circular Shareholding on Korean Corporate Value," with Prof. Inyeob Ji, Federation of Korean Industries (2020)

## Teaching Experience

**Instructor of Record** — *University of Colorado Boulder*

- Introduction to Statistics with Computer Applications (ECON 3818): Spring 2026, Summer 2026
- Principles of Macroeconomics (ECON 2020): Fall 2025

**Teaching Assistant** — *University of Colorado Boulder*

- Principles of Microeconomics (ECON 2010): Fall 2022, Fall 2024
- Principles of Macroeconomics (ECON 2020): Spring 2023, Fall 2023, Spring 2025, Summer 2025, Fall 2026

- Intermediate Microeconomic Theory (ECON 3070): Spring 2024

**Course Materials Development** *University of Colorado Boulder*

- ECON 3070: complete lecture notes, for Prof. Tania Barham (Summer 2024)
- ECON 3818: lecture notes, slides, R practice files and projects (Spring, Summer 2026)
- ECON 2020: lecture slides, recitation handouts, worksheets, and solutions (Fall 2025)
  *Lecture notes available upon request.*

**Teaching Assistant** *Dongguk University, Seoul*

- Principles of Microeconomics; Principles of Macroeconomics: 2020–2021
- Law and Economics: 2021–2022

## Scholarships, Awards & Fellowships

Third Year Paper Award 2024–2025
*Department of Economics, University of Colorado Boulder*

Reuben A. Zubrow Fellowship in Economics 2022–2023
*Department of Economics, University of Colorado Boulder*

Kwon Ohcheol Scholarship (full graduate scholarship) 2020–2021
*Department of Economics, Dongguk University*

Teaching Assistant Scholarship 2020–2021
*Dongguk University*

## Presentations

*University of Colorado Boulder Graduate Student Seminar* 2026

*University of Colorado Boulder Applied Microeconomics Seminar* 2025

*Korea's Allied Economic Associations Annual Meeting, Korean Economic Association* 2022

## Skills

Software: Stata, R, LaTeX
Languages: Korean (native), English (fluent), Japanese (intermediate, JLPT N3)

## References

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